Irrawaddy regions have long been home to a diverse range of non-Burmese ethnicities. Some of these groups live exclusively in modern-day Myanmar but many live on both sides of the various borders. Up to the nineteenth century, the evidence points to a degree of ethnic and religious tolerance,[2] even as the Burmese regions became increasingly dominated by Buddhism,[3] while the more marginal groups retained animist beliefs or adopted Christianity or Islam.

As discussed in the Introduction, all this means it is particularly important to separate the history of Arakan from that of Burma up to the 1800s. The core of the Burmese civilisation in central Burma, along the Irrawaddy Valley, is geographically and culturally linked to the Tibetan region, southwest China and the rest of East Asia. The south (the modern-day Mon and Tanintharyi provinces) is part of the wider Malaysian Peninsula[4] and has sea links to the south, including Sri Lanka and parts of Indonesia. In fact, this was the original vector for the early spread of Buddhism to Burma.

However, the Arakan region in the west has always been separated from the rest of Burma by a high and difficult-to-traverse coastal mountain range. As such, for most of its early history, both in terms of ethnic make-up and political-economic interaction, the natural links of the region were across the Bay of Bengal to India rather than with the rest of Burma. It was also a relatively poor province, reliant on subsistence agriculture and fishing, so it was generally of little interest to would-be conquerors. Indeed, early in modern Burmese history we see plenty of instances of warfare with Siam (now Thailand) over control of rich trade routes, but relatively little interest in Arakan.[5]

This state of isolation only changed from around 1000 AD, when the Rakhine ethnic group moved from central Burma to Arakan.[6] The modern-day province is named after this group. From then until late in the 1700s, Arakan had periods of dependence on the rulers of central Burma, periods of independence and even short periods when it dominated neighbouring Bangladesh. In 1784, Arakan was formally annexed by the Kingdom of Burma. However, this conquest brought the kingdom into conflict with the British, who also had an interest in the region. At the end of the First Anglo-Burmese War (1824–6), Arakan was appropriated by the British, and once again separated from Burmese rule. However, once the British had